

Aristophanes' Bacchylides: Reading *Birds* 1373–1409*

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Abstract

The significance of Aristophanes in the history of ancient literary criticism cannot be doubted. Equally undoubted is also the dismissive attitude that he appears to have towards the musical and poetic innovations of the late-fifth century BC. This position of his becomes essential when one considers the manner in which he treats the appraised canonical lyric poets and the condemned representatives of the New Dithyramb. This paper is concerned with the reading specifically of Bacchylides in Aristophanes. It argues in favour of the use of Bacchylides' Ode 5 to Hieron in *Birds* 1373–1409 as well as for the poem's reconfiguration by Kinesias within the context of the New Music. In the process it will allow us to comment on a number of poetic characteristics of Bacchylides' poetry and also to draw conclusions on Bacchylides' status within the melic tradition as the poet in-between classical lyric poetry and the New Music.

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Keywords

Bacchylides – Aristophanes – classical melic poetry – New Music – comic criticism

The distinction between old and new in literature is one of the central themes of literary criticism in antiquity.¹ It appears, in particular, in the comparisons and contrasts drawn by ancient critics between the *mousikē* and lyric poetry of the sixth and fifth century BC and the new “harmonic” and musical *status quo* in the later fifth century,² the era of the so-called New Music.³ A sense of an ending in nostalgic Athenian writings, such as those of Aristophanes⁴ and Plato, emphasises their pivotal status both in this cultural change and in ancient literary criticism. Aristophanes in particular comments on and parodies the song-culture of sixth and fifth century and this continuous poetic (r)evolution.⁵ His plays show an interest in the way music and poetry changed through time. His musical and poetic criticism mainly focuses on the innovations introduced in poetry in the late fifth-century and especially on the new dithyrambic music and the modern tragic scene.⁶ His position within

- 1 The phrase ‘literary criticism’ refers to both formal and informal literary criticism, on which see in particular Ford 2002, esp. 2–22. The new in music and the rhetoric of innovation are characteristics one can find in Greek discourse already in the Homeric epics. D’Angour (2011, 184–206) offers a comprehensive discussion of the idea of the new in antiquity, from Homer to the *De Musica* of ps-Plutarch. He also demonstrates (pp.207–224) how literary novelty still existed side by side with this criticism of the innovative.
- 2 For the first study of late-classical melic poetry, see LeVen (forthcoming), who explores the dynamics between tradition and innovation in its composition and practice.
- 3 E.g. Pherecr. fr.155 K-A; Eupolis fr.326 K-A; Pl.R.395d–400a, *Lg.*669c–670a, 700a–701b; Aristox. fr.124 Wehrli; ps-Plut. *De Mus.* 1137b, 1140d–f. For an extensive list of source material and testimonia on ancient music in general and its changing character in particular, Barker 1984.
- 4 Barker (1984, 93) considers Aristophanes as “our most significant fifth-century witness” of the musical developments in the later fifth century. Also Pöhlmann (2011) comments on those passages in Aristophanes where he is concerned with the New Music as well as with the ‘new tragedy’ of Euripides.
- 5 Eg. Ar. *Eq.*985–95; *Th.* 39–69, 95–174; *Ra.* 202–68, 1296–1318 with reference to the changing poet-ics. D’Angour (2006 and 2013) explores this idea of ‘revolution’ and ‘innovation’ that fractured musical experience, and concludes that it was mainly based on technical and stylistic novelty that consequently altered the discursive and sonic experience.
- 6 Zimmermann 1993a, 43–45. Csapo and Wilson (2009, 282) note that “suddenly in the later fifth century musical innovation became an ‘issue’ for the Greeks” (my emphasis). Their claim is confirmed by a number of scholarly studies. E.g. with reference to the New Dithyramb, Ford (2013, 320–322) shows how Aristophanes criticizes Aeschylus for the excess in compound

the literary process is especially important when one considers fifth-century melic poetry. Aristophanes includes in his comedies names, quotations and paraphrases of or allusions to the nine canonical lyric poets.⁷ Except one: Bacchylides. In marked contrast to his treatment of the rest of the canonical lyric poets, Aristophanes appears to have ignored Bacchylides, who is neither detected nor named in his comedies.⁸ Bremer suggests that Aristophanes does not make obscure allusions to poets, and does not include unknown quotations intelligible only to scholars and intellectuals. "It is the famous bits, the golden bits and evergreens from Greek poetry which he uses."⁹ But Bacchylides and his poetry were known to Athens only a generation before Aristophanes' productions and the Athenian audience must at least have been familiar with his name, if not with his poetry. It is therefore paradoxical that Bacchylides is marginalised in Aristophanes' work.

One should certainly not assume that Aristophanes, one of the most erudite dramatists of his time, did not include Bacchylides in his plays because he was not acquainted with his work. An intellectual who knew the poetry of an era prior to his own, and who was acutely aware of contemporary musical developments, would at least have known Bacchylides' Athenian civic poetry. The hypothesis that the audience, or at least part of the audience had not heard of his name also does not hold water. Bacchylides' Athenian commissions suggest that he was famous in Athens and consequently known to the Athenian audience at least in the 470s-460s BC.¹⁰ If Aristophanes only included in his plays such names and poetry as his audience was expected to recognise, he could have legitimately included him. His exclusion may thus be accidental. On the other hand, one should also recognise the possibility that Aristophanes'

epithets for which he also parodied the New Dithyramb. Wallace (2003, 75-82) has also shown that the *aulos* was also marked by revolutionary musical changes in early fifth century, an era that was defined as traditional and always in comparison to the new character of music and poetry in the latter half of the fifth century.

7 The term 'lyric' is used in this case to refer to the canonical nine lyric poets. One can find eight of the nine lyric poets included in Aristophanes' comedies in one way or another: Alcman Ar.Fr.590.52-53 K-A, Av.250-251, Lys.1296-1322; Alcaeus, Anacreon and Ibycus Ar.Th.160-163; Alcaeus and Anacreon Ar.Fr.235 K-A; Sappho Ar.Eq.730, Lys.839; Stesichorus Ar.Nu.967, Simonides Ar.Nu.1356, 1362; V.1410; Pax 697-698; Av.919; Pindar Ar.Av.939.

8 Carey (2011, 452) points out that "only Bacchylides goes unmentioned."

9 Bremer 1993 160, which should be consulted for further exploration.

10 There is a good case for the view that three out of the six complete civic compositions of Bacchylides (Odes 15, 16, and 19) may have been performed in Athenian festivals with musical and choral competitions. On Bacchylides' Athenian civic commissions, see among others Barron 1980; Maehler 1997, ad loc; id. 2004, ad loc; Fearn 2007, 174, 181, 237.

silence may mean that Bacchylides was not popular enough at *that* particular period of time; after all, Aristophanes composed and produced his plays over thirty years after Bacchylides' competitions in Athens. But it is at least as likely that we should seek for an explanation in the nature of Bacchylides' poetry, since Aristophanes tends to include lyric poets for specific purposes related to the characteristics of poet or genre.¹¹

This paper is concerned with the implicit presence of Bacchylides in Aristophanes. The discussion will focus particularly on the parody of Kinesias in *Birds* 1373-1409, a passage where one can detect language from Bacchylides' poetry. I will propose a reading of these allusions within the context of Aristophanes' stance on classic lyric and the New Music. After a brief analysis of Kinesias' performance in *Birds* and of the re-contextualisation of Bacchylides' language in his verses, I will draw attention to a number of stylistic features in Bacchylides' poetry that may reveal his position within the melic tradition. The Bacchylidean elements in the *Birds* will hopefully clarify Aristophanes' view on and reception of Bacchylides' poetics.

Kinesias on Stage

The city newly founded by Peisetairos is visited by two poets: the unnamed Poet who praises the city and leaves after he is given new clothes (Av.905-959) and the poet Kinesias who wants to gain feathers in order to become inspired and compose an 'ethereal' song for Clouducuckooland (Av.1373-1409). The first scene functions as a parody of the traditional and prestigious public choral celebrations.¹² The Poet appears suddenly, invokes the Muse, and flags his desire to sing for the new city (vv.905-907). The figure on stage is presented with specific, recognisable, melic characteristics; his performance merges the personae and poems of Pindar and Simonides,¹³ while recalling the foundation songs of the past that were commissioned by patrons such as Hieron of Syracuse (Ar. Av.924-929). This poetic caricature brings to mind the poets of

11 On the way in which Aristophanes incorporates the figures of the nine lyric poets in his work, Hadjimichael forthcoming (b).

12 The comment of the poet that he has been singing this newly-founded city for a long, long time (v.921 *πάλαι πάλαι δὴ τήνδ' ἐγὼ κλήζω πόλιν*) hints at his role as one of the commissioned poets of the past, who has already sung for the foundation of Aetna (v.926) and in retrospect the newly-founded Clouducuckooland.

13 Ar.Av.919 *κατὰ τὰ Σιμωνίδου* ('in the style of Simonides'), v.939 *Πινδάρειον ἔπος* ('a Pindaric saying').

the classical period and the varied civic commissions that were publicly performed in archaic and classical times.¹⁴ Peisetairos however rejects the norms that used to signal the importance of a new colony: Cloudcuckooland does not need the solemn poets of celebration. The comic rebuff of the services of the encomiastic Poet brings to mind the struggle between old and new: those traditional practices in the Athenian society from which Peisetairos and Euelpides had escaped, in order to found a new city that did not resemble the detestable culture of old. Another kind of old and new is also ‘performed’ in front of Peisetairos: old classical and traditional melic poetry versus new and modern music. This scene, where the prestigious choral celebrations are parodied, should be juxtaposed with the appearance of Kinesias on stage (vv.1373-1409). This may give us a snapshot of Aristophanes’ attitude towards poetry and music and of the way he ponders upon the old and the new.

Kinesias appears on stage after Peisetairos has been pestered by a number of intruders whom he chases away. As in the case of the Poet, he appears unannounced and enters the stage singing. The poet parodied in this scene is a contemporary Athenian poet, who is specifically classified as a dithyrambic poet, a *kykliodidaskalos*¹⁵ (Av.1378, 1388, 1403f), and bears the name of one of the representatives of the New Music on Athens’ musical stage.

Κι: Ἀναπέτομαι δὴ πρὸς Ὀλυμπον πτερύγεσσι κούφαις·

πέτομαι δ’ ὁδὸν ἄλλοτ’ ἐπ’ ἄλλαν μελέων—¹⁶

Πε. Τουτὶ τὸ πρᾶγμα φορτίου δεῖται πτερῶν.

1375

- 14 Ar.Av.917-919 with references to two types of melic songs: songs performed by *kykloi khoroi* and *partheneia*. Dunbar (1995, ad loc) supposes that this reference (Av.919) could mean “in pure classical style,” whereas Swift (2010, 174) suggests that *partheneia* in this passage may be “a catch-all for female song.”
- 15 Martin (2009, 91) insists that, in contrast to the unnamed poet in the previous scene, Kinesias is not a wandering poet, but a *kykliodidaskalos*. His preoccupation with *kykloi khoroi*, suggests Martin (p.92), is more allusively indicated by the fact that his plan of getting wings stops when Peisetairos gives him a *khoregos* and a tribe of birds (Av.1405-07). On v.1378 as referring to the *kyklios khoros*, Fearn 2007, 165-181; id. 2013, 139.
- 16 Cf. B.fr.5 “Ἐτερος ἐξ ἑτέρου σοφός/ τό τε πάλοι τό τε νῦν. οὐδὲ γὰρ ῥᾷστον/ ἀρρήτων ἐπέων πύλας/ ἐξευρεῖν. (‘One becomes wise after being influenced by another both in the past and now, for it is not easy to find the gates of those words that were left unsaid’). The phonic aspects of language and ‘sound figures’ were important for New Music, and this resulted in repetition of words and syllables. The detailed description of the use of phonemes in the New Dithyramb in Csapo 2004, 222-205 and 2011, 82-85 has shown that the new poets prioritised sound over sense.

- Κι. ἀφόβῳ φρενὶ σώματί τε νέαν ἐφέπων-
 Πε. Ἀσπαζόμεσθα φιλύρινον Κινησίαν.
 Τί δεῦρο πόδα σὺ κυλλὸν ἀνὰ κύκλον κυκλεῖς;
 Κι. Ὅρνις γενέσθαι βούλομαι
 λιγύφθογγος ἀηδῶν. 1380
- Πε. Παῦσαι μελωδῶν, ἀλλ' ὅ τι λέγεις εἰπέ μοι.
 Κι. Ὑπὸ σοῦ πτερωθεὶς βούλομαι μετάρσιος
 ἀναπτόμενος ἐκ τῶν νεφελῶν καινὰς λαβεῖν
 ἀεροδονήτους καὶ νιφοβόλους ἀναβολάς. 1385
- Πε. Ἐκ τῶν νεφελῶν γὰρ ἂν τις ἀναβολὰς λάβοι;
 Κι. Κρέμαται μὲν οὖν ἐντεῦθεν ἡμῶν ἡ τέχνη.
 Τῶν διθυράμβων γὰρ τὰ λαμπρὰ γίγνεται
 ἀέρια καὶ σκότι' ἄττα καὶ κυναυγέα
 καὶ πτεροδόνητα· σὺ δὲ κλύων εἴσει τάχα. 1390
- Πε. Οὐ δῆτ' ἔγωγε.
 Κι. Νῆ τὸν Ἡρακλέα σύ γε.
 Ἄπαντα γὰρ δίειμί σοι τὸν ἀέρα.
 Εἶδωλα πετηνῶν
 αἰθεροδρόμων
 οἰωνῶν ταναοδείρων—
 Πε. ὦ ὅπ. 1395
- Κι. ἀλίδρομον ἀλάμενος
 ἅμ' ἀνέμων πνοαῖσι βαίην.
 Πε. Νῆ τὸν Δί' ἧ' γῶ σου καταπαύσω τὰς πνοάς.
 Κι. τοτὲ μὲν νοτίαν στείχων πρὸς ὁδόν,
 τοτὲ δ' αὖ βορέα· σώμα πελάζων
 ἀλίμενον αἰθέρος αὔλακα τέμνων. 1400
- Χαρίεντά γ', ὦ πρεσβῦτ', ἐσοφίσω καὶ σοφά.
 Πε. Οὐ γὰρ σὺ χαίρεις πτεροδόνητος γενόμενος;
 Κι. Ταυτί πεποίηκας τὸν κυκλιοδιδασκαλον,
 ὃς ταῖσι φυλαῖς περιμάχητός εἰμ' αἰεῖ;
 Πε. Βούλει διδάσκειν καὶ παρ' ἡμῖν οὖν μένων 1405
- Λεωτροφίδη χορὸν πετομένων ὀρνέων
 Κεκροπίδα φυλήν;
 Κι. Καταγελᾷς μου, δῆλος εἶ.
 Ἄλλ' οὖν ἔγωγ' οὐ παύσομαι, τοῦτ' ἴσθ' ὅτι,
 πρὶν ἂν πτερωθεὶς διαδράμω τὸν ἀέρα.
 (An.1373-1409)

C: 'Up I fly on light wings of Olympus', from one path of song to another I fly...

P: Here's something that'll need a whole load of wings.

C: 'With fearless mind and body pursuing that path that is new.'

P: Welcome, lime-woody Cinesias! Why have you circled your circling club-foot here?

C: 'To become a bird is my desire, a clear-voiced nightingale.'

P: Do stop singing, and just tell me what you mean.

C: I want you to give me wings, so I can fly up aloft and gather new wind-blown, snow-clad *anabolai* from the clouds.

P: Can one gather *anabolai* from the clouds?

C: Oh yes! Our entire craft hangs on them. The glories of a dithyramb are all airy and misty and purple-glistening and whirled on feathers—listen and you'll understand at once.

P: Oh no I won't.

C: Oh yes, you will! 'For you I'll traverse the whole air, a shadow of winged, walking-on-aether, slim-necked birds...'

P: Hey!

C: 'May I take the road to the sea, and walk on the breaths of the winds...'

P: By God! I'll stop your breath!

C: 'Now taking a southerly way, now nearing the north with my body, ploughing the harbourless furrow of aether...'. What a clever trick you've played on me, old man! Charming!

P: Don't you like being whirled on feathers, then?

C: Is this what you do to circular-chorus trainer, the one that the tribes are always fighting to get?

P: Would you like to stay here, then, and train the tribe of Kekropis for Leotrophides as a chorus of flying birds?

C: You're making fun of me, I can tell. But I won't stop, you know, till I've got my wings and wander through the air. (trans. Barker 1984)

Kinesias probably appears on stage as the representative of the poetic innovations of the New Music. Yet he uses language derived from the poetry of Bacchylides, a poet of the classical era of melic poetry. Dunbar comments on how Kinesias' language in vv.1373-1409 is close to Bacchylides' Ode 5.16-33.¹⁷

χρυσάμπυκος Οὐρανίας
κλεινὸς θεράπων· ἐθέλει

17 Dunbar 1995, 665.

γάρυν ἐκ στηθέων χέων
 αἰνεῖν Ἰέρωνα. βαθὺν
 δ' αἰθέρα ξουθαίσι τάμνων
 ὑψοῦ πτερύγεσσι ταχεί-
 αῖς αἰετὸς εὐρύανακτος ἄγγελος
 Ζηνὸς ἐρισφάραγος
 θαρσεῖ κρατερᾷ πίσυνος
 ἰσχὺϊ, πτάσσοντι δ' ὄρνι-
 χες λιγύφθογγοι φόβωι.
 (B.5.13-23)¹⁸

... a renowned servant of Urania with her golden snood. He wishes to pour his voice from his breast and praise Hieron. Cutting through the deep sky with broad swift wings on high the eagle, messenger of wide-ruling, loud-roaring Zeus, is bold, trusting in his mighty strength, and shrill-voiced birds cower with terror. (trans. Cairns and Howie 2010)

Though one can never be sure in the absence of direct quotation (and there is too little similarity of detail to allow one to judge confidently),¹⁹ the language here is highly suggestive. In both passages the main theme is flying and reaching the sky, and similarities in language and thought are remarkable. Both Bacchylides and Kinesias portray their desire to sing. The theme of patronage is accompanied by the will of the poet in both cases. Although the poet assimilated to the eagle *par excellence* is Pindar,²⁰ the extended description of the poet as a bird is suggestive of Bacchylides. Where Bacchylides uses the eagle as an implicit symbol of the poet and in order to express the poet's self-confidence in his task to praise Hieron,²¹ Aristophanes' passage makes the connotations more explicit. It seems that Kinesias has taken the main ideas employed in Bacchylides and elaborated on them. The specifics of his song and the descriptive details added to the received passage seem to have clarified

18 The passages of Bacchylides are taken from H. Maehler's 2003 Teubner edition, and the passages of Aristophanes from N.G. Wilson's 2008 OCT edition. Translations, including those in footnotes, are my own, unless otherwise stated.

19 According to Hinds (1998, 120), allusive relationship "is built upon a perception of similarity and a perception of difference."

20 Σ. Pi. O.2.157a; Σ. N.3.143; Σ. N.5.39. On the image of the eagle in Pindar, Pfeijffer 1994, 305-315; on whether the eagle is or is not applied to Pindar, Stoneman 1976 and Angeli Bernardini 1977.

21 On the image of the eagle in Bacchylides, Lefkowitz 1969, 53-57 and Pfeijffer 1994, 316-317 who argues that it is retrospectively applied to the poet.

its meaning:²² the first-person singular attributed to the voice and persona of the performing poet coupled with the present tense for the act of flying (ἀναπέτομαι), which was presumably visually executed or at least mimicked on stage, and the repetition of his intense desire (βούλομαι) collectively paints a picture that is more immediate and vivid than the original.

Similarities between the two passages are striking in terms of language and imagery, and are suggestive, if not of direct imitation, at least of adaptation of distinctive Bacchylidean features. Kinesias has expanded, in a random order, on the main ideas in Bacchylides' passage. As the eagle cleaves the deep heavens with his feathers, Kinesias flies from north to south across the infinite ether and flutters along the thousand paths of poetry, just as Bacchylides' Muse can choose from many and different paths to praise Hieron's virtue (B.5.31-33). Whereas in Bacchylides the emphasis is placed on the fear that the eagle's grand flying causes to the 'clear-voiced' birds, Kinesias gives prominence to his *fearless* flight stimulated by his new poetry. He wants to become a 'clear-voiced' nightingale, an adjective Bacchylides uses of himself in B.10.10 'a clear-voiced bee'—λιγύφθογγον μέλισσαν. The Homeric adjective λιγύφθογγον is a *hapax* in surviving melic poetry (choral or monodic), whereas Bacchylides uses it twice, in one case referring to himself.²³ He is also the only melic poet who employs the nightingale image.

πράξα[ντι] δ' εὖ
οὐ φέρει κόσμ[ον σι]ω-
πά· σὺν δ' ἄλαθ[εῖαι] καλῶν
καὶ μελιγλώσσου τις ὑμνήσει χάριν
Κηῖας ἀηδόνος.
(B.3.94-98)

For one that has done well silence brings no ornament; but with truth of noble deeds someone will hymn, too, the grace of the honey-tongued Cean nightingale. (trans. Cairns and Howie 2010)

Kinesias combines the two images (and passages) in his words, as he expresses his desire to become a λιγύφθογγος ἀηδών.

22 The comment on how Kinesias clarifies the meaning of Bacchylides' verses, an argument based on his convoluted verses, is made in comparison to the original passage in Ode 5 that appears to be more 'pragmatic' and less 'overwhelming' than the adaptation. The reactions of Peisetairos who asks for an explanation, as the meaning of Kinesias' words is not clear, underline the obscure nature and unintelligibility of which the new poets were often accused.

23 B.10.10 λιγύφθογγον μέλισσαν; B.5.23 ὄρνιθες λιγύφθογγοι φέβωι.

This fusion of features from diverse poetic manners—New Dithyramb,²⁴ Bacchylides and Anacreon²⁵—creates a musical pastiche on the Aristophanic stage. Uttered by Kinesias in a random order, Bacchylides' verses become part of the New Music he represents and gain a different resonance from the one they had in the original text.²⁶ In light of recent discussions on the role of musicians and pipers in the New Dithyramb, Barker postulates that the night-ingle is an enigmatic figure in Aristophanes' *Birds*.²⁷ After a close examination of vv.209-22 and vv.665-84, he suggests that Aristophanes associates it with the New Dithyramb and the degraded state of music. His conclusions, which seem plausible, suggest an additional meaning for the phrase λιγύφθογγος ἀηδών as applied to Kinesias. The combination of a Homeric/Bacchylidean adjective with the bird that symbolises New Music in this particular comedy suggests a combination between old melic song and New Dithyramb on stage.

Kinesias here may indeed be turned into the native scapegoat for mockery of the light-toned and voluble compositions of the New Dithyrambists, and he is himself expelled from the city just like the representative of the traditional classical melic poetry. Both of them are ridiculed, and neither is welcome. They are not needed, they are not good enough, or they represent the Athenian past and present that the characters wish to leave behind. Nonetheless, we should perhaps ask ourselves how much of New Music we actually have in the passage. Kinesias appears as ludicrously 'airy', a feature that is common in the portrayal of the New Dithyrambists in Aristophanes,²⁸ and he wishes to compose songs with *anabolai*. But although Peisetairos is not happy with what he hears

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- 24 Pöhlmann (2011, 40-42) analyses the metrical structure of Kinesias' lyrics and shows that they are good examples of the style of the New Dithyramb. See also the metrical analysis in Parker 1997, 340-344. Pöhlmann (2011, 42) notes how v.1379 can be taken as criticism against the lame metrical foot Kinesias adopts in his lyrics. LeVen (2013b, 49 with n17) focuses on the separate elements of the compounds and explores the recycling of sound and thought in the passage.
- 25 Ar. Av.1372-74 ~ Anacreon fr.378 PMG ἀναπέτομαι δὴ πρὸς Ὀλυμπον πτερύγεσσι κούφηις/ διὰ τὸν ἔρωτ'· οὐ γὰρ ἔμοι <-υ> θέλει συννηθᾶν. ('I fly on light wings to Olympus in search of Eros; for [he] does not wish to pass his youth with me').
- 26 Hinds (1998, 101) points out that both the alluding text and the model text gain a different meaning in the process of allusion, but not both at the same time. Fowler (1997, 18) also argues that this kind of difference affects not only the meaning of the target but also our perception of it and of the scene in which it is used.
- 27 Barker 2004.
- 28 Cf. Pax 827-831. Kugelmeier (1997, 221): "Die physische Leichtigkeit des Fliegens wird zur Metaphor für geistiges 'Leichtgewicht', das der Kunst des Kinesias unterstellt werden soll." On the use of air as a substance of the metaphorical language of criticism and its negative connotations, Wright (2012) 110-113.

as he does not understand it,²⁹ Kinesias' words lack the meaningless grandiloquence that supposedly characterises the empty lyrics of the new poets.³⁰ As mentioned above, while his song recalls features of the New Dithyramb, it additionally alludes to a couplet by Anacreon and reworks Bacchylides. This particular scene invites us to contemplate the nature of 'the innovative' in literature,³¹ especially as Aristophanes' Kinesias in the *Birds*³² sounds more like Bacchylides than like Kinesias himself.

Bacchylides' 'New Style'

As Ford argues persuasively, *Av*.1373-1385 imply that "the new dithyramb relied excessively on striking epithets," a comment supported by both the scholion on the passage³³ and the attention comedy draws on the accumulation of epithets in the New Dithyramb.³⁴ It has long been recognised that one of the main features of Bacchylides' poetry is *enargeia*,³⁵ an aesthetic and narrative quality achieved primarily through stylistic ornamentation.³⁶ Bacchylides'

29 Ford (2013, 319) enumerates the accusations one can find in vv.1373-1385 against Kinesias' song and the poetry he represents.

30 E.g. *Ar.Nu*.330-340, 960-972; *Th*.30-69. Cf. LeVen (2013b) 49n17 for a stylistic analysis of the passage in the context of the stylistic features of the New Music.

31 Innovation is often defined by its relationship to tradition, and tradition is recognised as such only because of innovation.

32 Cf. *Ar.Ra*.153 with Σ. ad loc on the virtuoso choral movements of Kinesias' songs. On Kinesias in Old Comedy, Kugelmeier (1997, 208-248) who analyses all the instances in which he is ridiculed in comedy and associates his findings with additional primary sources.

33 Σ *Ar.Av*.1383 παίζει δὲ πρὸς τὰ ποιήματα τῶν διθυραμβοποιῶν· ἔθος γὰρ αὐτοῖς τοιαῦτα ἐπιθετα λέγειν. ἅμα δὲ καὶ πρὸς τὸ κοῦφον αὐτῶν. ('He ridicules the poems of the dithyrambic poets: for it is said that it was their habit to use epithets, mainly because of their vain character').

34 Ford 2013, 319-321, quotation from 319.

35 Kirkwood 1966, 98-101.

36 Segal (1985, 237) observes that one can find in Bacchylides nineteen compound epithets that are not present in other poetry. Bacchylides' compound epithets are constructed with elements denoting dark, crimson, and shining (*χρᾶνο-/φοινικο-/ἀγλαο-*). Cairns (2010, 37-41) offers a rich presentation of Bacchylides' preference of epithets, mainly compounds and of visual character. A statistical analysis in Garcia Romero 2000, 51n15 shows that 62% of substantives in Bacchylides' dithyrambs are qualified by one or more adjectives, in contrast to Pindar's dithyrambs where the percentage is 47.6%. If we extend the quest to the victory odes, Bacchylides' odes appear to be more decorative with 48.7% in comparison to 44.5% in Pindar. LeVen (2013b) emphasises the ability of the New Dithyramb to create visual images and points out how this is facilitated by the use of compound adjectives (p.49).

use of epithets, often *hapax legomena* and neologisms,³⁷ endows his narrative with gracefulness and clarity of detail. One can detect in the passage parodied by Kinesias (Ode 5.13-28) the power of Bacchylides' narrative to 'animate' his images and descriptions. All the fundamental nouns in the passage are accompanied by an epithet: Urania is called 'the one with the golden snood' (χρυσάμπυκος) and her *therapōn* 'renowned' (κλεινός), the sky is 'deep' (βαθύν), the eagle is 'bold' (πίσυνος) and has 'swift' (ταχείαις) wings, Zeus is 'wide-ruling' and 'loud-roaring' (εὐρύανακτος, ἐρισφαράγους) and his strength is 'mighty' (κρατερᾶι), while the birds are 'shrill-voiced' (λιγύφθογγοι). The abundance of epithets in this passage slows down the narrative and creates a pause, which forces us to become conscious of the details.³⁸ The narrative picture becomes visual: we watch the eagle flying through the skies and, as our gaze follows the movement of his wings, the accumulation of the descriptive details adds power and vividness to the image.³⁹ The ornate texture of Bacchylides' narrative approaches the seductive imagery of poems of the New Music: newly-fashioned epithets and detailed descriptions in poems of the new poets made variety and *poikilia*⁴⁰ (in the sense of 'ornamentation') the main aesthetic effects of their poetry.

Bacchylides' narrative comes to a standstill with the visual details and the intensity of his descriptions in a manner similar to the way in which he exposes his characters' psychological turmoil, their emotions, *pathos* and *ethos*.⁴¹ The audience is invited to sympathise with Croesus' despair, and to feel sorrow for the fate of his daughters who weep and mourn in Ode 3; Heracles and Meleager are portrayed as vulnerable in Ode 5, and they arouse pity as they bring upon themselves their destruction; the narratives vividly express the fear of Aegeus and the Athenians in Ode 18 for the unknown figure that approaches

37 Gentili and Catenacci 2007, 341.

38 Segal 1976, 101, 107.

39 Extremely vivid and visual narratives appear in Bacchylides' athletic descriptions, on which see Hadjimichael forthcoming (a).

40 LeVen 2013a, in an attempt to explore the sensual and aesthetic experience of *mousikē*, examines *poikilos* and *poikilia* "as terms of aesthetic and self-conscious discourse on the nature of the sensory experience and its effects" (p.236). She notes in particular (p.240) that *poikilia*, as a term referring to musical complexity, becomes "one of the characteristics of the (much-discussed) virtuoso style of New Music." Csapo (2004, 227) explains how the New Music appealed "to senses, especially to the ears and eye of the mind." West (1992, 363) characterises the language of Timotheus' *Persae* as elaborate, exuberant, highly-coloured and with tendency to concentrate on pictorial details in his narrative.

41 Cf. Gentili and Catenacci 2007, 341, on how Bacchylides differs from Pindar in that he often analyses his characters' psychology; Csapo (2004, 228) comments on how *ethopoieia* was one of the main quests of the New Music.

the city, the agony of Proteus in Ode 11 for the frantic state of his daughters, the panic of the youths on the Cretan ship after Theseus' dive in Ode 17 and their joy when he re-emerges from the sea. Bacchylides concentrates on storytelling more than Pindar,⁴² and this noticeably affects the narrative quality of his poems. His mythical narratives are characterised by theatricality and dramatic mimesis,⁴³ mainly through dialogues and direct speech, and his mythical characters, who are given voice in the text, are often endowed with the dramatic quality of characters in Greek tragic drama. Theatricality, virtuosity of performance and music volubility were some of the most important innovations the new poets supposedly introduced to the established music and poetry of the time.⁴⁴ Bacchylides' Ode 18 displays all of the above features—ornamentation, visualisation, vividness, theatricality, *ethopoieia*—and two additional characteristics. For brevity's sake I cite only strophes A and Δ.

- A' Βασιλεῦ τᾶν ἱερᾶν Ἀθανᾶν,
 <ΧΟΡΟΣ> τῶν ἀβροβίων ἄναξ Ἰώνων,
 τί νέον ἔκλαγε χαλκοκώδων
 σάλπιγξ πολεμητῆαν αἰοδᾶν;
 5 ἦ τις ἀμετέρας χθονὸς
 δυσμενῆς ὄρι' ἀμφιβάλλει
 στραταγέτας ἀνήρ;
 ἦ ληισταὶ κακομάχανοι
 ποιμένων ἀέκατι μῆλων

42 Cf. Kirkwood 1966; Fearn 2012.

43 Calame 2013, 341 entitles his section dealing with Bacchylides' dithyramb "The mimetic narratives of Bacchylides."

44 West 1992, 44. Zimmermann (1992, 118-128), and Csapo (2004, 207-229) (2011, 65-89) offer detailed accounts of the characteristics of the New Music; with reference to the character of the dithyrambic genre, Zimmermann (1993b, 51-54) gives a short overview of the changing process of the dithyramb between the fifth and second centuries; Ieranò (1997, 37-48 and 205-232) gathers and analyses the relevant testimonia on the innovations introduced by the New Dithyramb; Wilson (2004, 303-306) considers briefly the manner in which stringed instruments were affected by the New Music; Csapo and Wilson (2009, 287-290) offer a concise overview of the musical characteristics of the New Music with special emphasis on Timotheus; D'Angour (2011, 202-206) accompanies his overview of the main technical and performative features of the New Music with allusions to a few reactionary tendencies. See also Richter, 1968; West 1992, 356-372; D'Angour 2006; Fearn 2007, 181-205; Power 2010, 82-86, 110-115 and 500-516; Kowalzig and Wilson 2013, 19-23; Franklin 2013; Power 2013.

- 10 σεύοντ' ἀγέλας βίαι;
 ἢ τί τοι κραδίαν ἀμύσσει;
 φθέγγευ· δοκέω γάρ εἴ τιτι βροτῶν
 ἀλκίμων ἐπικουρίαν
 καὶ τὴν ἔμμεναι νέων,
 15 ὦ Πανδίωνος υἱὲ καὶ Κρεοῦσας.

...

- Δ' Δύο οἱ φῶτε μόνους ἀμαρτεῖν
 <ΑΙΓΕΥΣ> λέγει, περὶ φαιδίμοισι δ' ὥμοις
 ξίφος ἔχειν <ἐλεφανόκωπον>,
 ξεστοὺς δὲ δὺ' ἐν χέρεσσ' ἄκοντας
 50 κηϋτυκτον κυνέαν Λάκαι-
 ναν κρατὸς πέρι πυρσοχαίτου·
 χιτῶνα πορφύρεον
 στέρνοις τ' ἀμφί, καὶ οὐλίον
 Θεσσαλὰν χλαμύδ'· ὁμμάτων δὲ
 55 στίλβειν ἄπο Λαμνίαν
 φοίνισσαν φλόγα· παῖδα δ' ἔμ <μ>εν
 πρῶθηβον, ἀρηϊῶν δ' ἀθυρμάτων
 μεμνᾶσθαι πολέμου τε καὶ
 χαλκεοκτύπου μάχας·
 δίζησθαι δὲ φιλαγλάους Ἀθάνας.

Α'

King of holy Athens, lord of the delicately-living Ionians, why did the bronze-mouthed trumpet sound its warlike song just now? Does some hostile general surround the borders of our land? Or do mischievous robbers drive off forcibly the flocks of sheep against the shepherd's will? Or what is it that tears your heart? Speak; for I think that you, if any mortal, son of Pandion and Creusa, have brave forces to help you.

...

Δ'

He says that only two men accompany him; he has a sword with ivory hilt slung from his bright shoulders, two polished spears in his hands, a well-made Laconian cap about his fire-red hair, a purple tunic over his chest and woolly Thessalian cloak; from his eyes flashes red Lemnian flame; he is a young man in his earliest youth, and he has in his mind the toys of Ares, and war and battles with clang of bronze; and he seeks for splendour-loving Athens.⁴⁵

45 Translation by Campbell 1992 with a few alterations.

Plato's ethical and moral anxiety centred predominantly on the unruly and liberated melodic and instrumental realisation of the New Music that favoured sound instead of content, as well as on the lawless mixing of musical *harmoniai* and the chaotic melodies of the new poems (Pl.R.398d).⁴⁶ One can reasonably assume that the performance of Ode 18 was 'escorted' by the blare of a military trumpet (v.4. σάλπιγξ). The trumpet may have possibly replaced *ad locum* the *aulos* that normally accompanied dithyrambic performances in classical Athens,⁴⁷ or may have led off the performance of the poem only for its notes to give way to the sound of the *aulos*. Notwithstanding the non-association of the trumpet with the *harmoniai* that Plato worries about, its penetrating tone, mostly associated with battles (v.4. πολεμῆϊαν αἰοιδάν), and its introduction in the musical territory of the *aulos* must have struck the audience as bizarre, if not horrendous, and inappropriate.⁴⁸

The sonic innovation in the poem is also accompanied by a structural and performative novelty. Bacchylides seems to be experimenting with the form of the dithyramb in this poem, and its dramatic and dialogic structure makes its performance a problematic case. Whereas on the one hand the poem looks backwards to the "amoebean style of the original form"⁴⁹ of the dithyramb, as that was envisaged by Archilochus in his role as the *exarchos* of the chorus (fr.120W), it simultaneously looks forward to its generic evolution into the tragic genre. Although it is easier for modern readers to grasp the outline of the dialogue, it is likely that the dialogic nature of the exchange was also marked in the actual performance. The distribution of the parts to the chorus follows tragic patterns and this could have been the manner in which the contemporary audience perceived it.⁵⁰ Csapo draws attention to the

46 Wright (2012, 82) concludes that the way in which comedy considers the new forms of art and culture dangerous is analogous to Plato's and Aristotle's ideological objections to the New Music; cf. Pl.R.424c.

47 Cf. Arist. *Pol.*1342^a32-^b12, where he mentions the Phrygian mode as characteristic of the *aulos* and the dithyramb, and in retrospect the association of the *aulos* with the dithyramb.

48 It should be noted here that the trumpet is not mentioned in any other poems of melic poetry.

49 D'Angour 2013, 206.

50 Jebb (1906, 233); Maehler (2004, 193); Fearn (2007, 220 and 314n.173); Athanassaki (2009, 314) have recognised, among others, that this is a unique poem within the extant dithyrambic collection. Its dramatic structure and dialogic form associate the ode with tragedy, and the actual distribution of the parts to the chorus would bring to the audience's mind the tragic chorus. This particular performance would have suggested scenes in tragedy with these kinds of structural features, especially scenes in which the chorus attains a speaking

differentiation of roles within the chorus during the performance of the New Dithyramb often “at the cost of the chorus’ traditional unity”⁵¹ and links this quality with direct speech and the introduction of recitative verse. It is clear that Bacchylides breaks, if not the unity of his chorus, at least the unity of both their voice and unified role.⁵²

Furthermore, the Platonic school of thought condemned the New Music and its representatives⁵³ not solely for their liberal musical modulations, but also because they contrived to mix *thrēnoi* with hymns, paeans with dithyrambs, and to imitate aulodic songs and music in their kitharodic genres (Pl. *Lg.*700d-e). Ode 18 is an experiment with the dithyramb itself, and this structural independence from the norm of the traditionally chorally performed and triadically structured dithyrambs creates additional perplexity in any attempts to define generic boundaries. The Platonic view saw the dithyramb as predominantly a narrative genre (R.394b9-394c5), and Ode 18 does not fit into this frame. The choreutai assume roles within the performance and the direct speech gives the poem a mimetic quality. This also brings it closer to the structural and performative development that finally assimilated the dithyramb to the *nomos*.

Διὰ τί οἱ μὲν νόμοι οὐκ ἐν ἀντιστρόφοις ἐποιοῦντο, αἱ δὲ ἄλλαι ᾠδαὶ αἱ χορικάι; ἢ ὅτι οἱ μὲν νόμοι ἀγωνιστῶν ἦσαν, ὧν ἤδη μιμεῖσθαι δυναμένων καὶ διατείνεσθαι ἢ ᾧ ἐγένετο μακρὰ καὶ πολυειδής; καθάπερ οὖν καὶ τὰ ῥήματα, καὶ τὰ μέλη τῇ μιμήσει ἡκολούθει αἰεὶ ἕτερα γινόμενα. μᾶλλον γὰρ τῷ μέλει ἀνάγκη μιμεῖσθαι ἢ

role within the play: scenes in which the chorus exchanges words with a character, messenger-speeches wherein off-stage events are narrated, the tragic *amoibaion*, on which Popp 1968, 221-237; Zimmermann 1984, 153-261, or choral songs in which the chorus is divided into *hemichoria*. While it is not possible to know how the ode was performed, it is tempting to suggest the existence of a *koryphaios*, or performance by two *hemichoria*, one of which would have represented Aegeus. Jebb (1906, 233-4) claims that the ode is an exchange between the *koryphaios* and Aegeus, whereas Fearn (2007, 207n.153) finds plausible a performance in which the *koryphaios* holds the role of Aegeus.

51 Csapo 2004, 214 and 2011, 74.

52 Cf. the song with which Agathon enters in *Ar.Th.*101-129, where he pretends to be leading a female chorus who sing with him alternately.

53 West (1992, 369-72) lays out both resistance to and favourable criticism of the New Music. This confirms the often biased character of our sources, and particularly of modern scholarship, that emphasises the negative criticism of New Music in contrast to often admiring comments. See e.g. Antiphanes fr.207 K-A, where a character praises Philoxenus as the best of poets; Xen. *Mem.*1.4.3 where Melannipides is named as the best dithyrambist. On the special popularity of Timotheus in antiquity, Csapo and Wilson 2009, 279-281.

τοῖς ῥήμασιν. διὸ καὶ οἱ διθύραμβοι, ἐπειδὴ μιμητικοὶ ἐγένοντο, οὐκέτι ἔχουσιν ἀντιστροφούς, πρότερον δὲ εἶχον.

(Arist. [Pr.] 918^b13-20)

Why were *nomoi* not composed antistrophically, while other songs, those for choruses were? It is because *nomoi* were pieces for competitors, and since they were able to perform imitatively and to sustain lengthy-exertions, their song became long and multiform. Like the words, the melodies followed the imitation in being continually varied. There was even greater need for imitation in melody than in the words. That is why the dithyrambs, when they became imitative, no longer had antistrophes as they did before. (trans. Barker 1984)

This extract from pseudo-Aristotelian *Problems*⁵⁴ reveals a number of important issues related to Bacchylides' Ode 18. The theoretical framing for the generic distinction between *nomos* and dithyramb focuses on structural and performative characteristics ([οὐκ] ἐν ἀντιστροφῶν), on acoustic changes (τὰ μέλη... ἀεὶ ἕτερα γινόμενα) as well as on the mimetic function of the performance (μιμεῖσθαι). I will not go into the Greek theorization about mimesis or the issue of professionalism; I will only remark that [ps-]Aristotle is commenting on a dithyrambic evolution that becomes evident in the abandonment of the traditional antistrophic/triadic form that favoured choral performances, in the alteration of melodies in order to serve the mimetic end of the performance, and in an almost generic syncretism between *nomos* and dithyramb. I draw attention to the first and third comment of [ps-]Aristotle, both of which can be detected in Ode 18. Up to this point my comments on the poem have focused on the performative characteristics that map onto its dialogic form. These, as mentioned above, look both backwards and forwards. The comments of [ps-]Aristotle add an additional piece to the performative puzzle of this poem: the author sees the lack of strophes and antistrophes in the structure and performance of dithyrambs as drawing closer to the performative nature of the *nomos*. Following the passage's train of thought, it becomes unsuitable for choral performances. Even though one cannot comment with certainty on the performance of this particular ode, the passage from the *Problemata* offers us a chronological boundary for this kind of astrophic dithyramb. That is when they become mimetic (ἐπειδὴ μιμητικοὶ ἐγένοντο) and, I would add, innovative, New. Ode 18 seems to be somewhere in the middle. It does not

54 See Peponi 2013, 362-364; Franklin 2013, 232 for two interpretations of the passage in connection with the dithyramb.

abandon the strophic structure completely, as it consists of four strophes, but it does abandon the triadic structure of the 'traditional' dithyramb. It therefore collates through both its structure and performance facets of a number of diverse genres and of a number of different developments, both generic and chronological: the proto-dithyramb whose performance was presumably encompassed both by a chorus and an *exarchos*, the tragic genre as the biological *telos* of the dithyrambic evolution, and the *nomos* as the other end of the spectrum to the 'traditional' dithyramb towards which the abandonment of triadic structure gradually led.

A kind of blurring of generic boundaries, this time within the poetics of the song and not its performance, can also be detected in Ode 17. Despite its Hellenistic classification as a dithyramb, the existence of paeanic markers at the conclusion of the poem has led to a number of modern scholarly disagreements on its poetic genre.⁵⁵

ἡῖθεοι δ' ἐγγύθεν
 νέοι παιάνιξαν ἐρατᾷ ὀπί.
 Δάλιε, χοροῖσι Κηῖων 130
 φρένα ἰανθείς
 ὄπαζε θεόπομπον ἐσθλῶν τύχαν.
 (B.17.128-132)

And nearby the youths raised a paeon with their lovely voice. Delian Apollo, rejoice with the choruses of the Ceans and grant a god-sent fortune of blessings.

The poem deconstructs its own narrative-frames, and the paeanic song of the youths endorses the performance itself, as the ode and the external song concludes with the sound of the internal paeon and the invocation of Delian Apollo.⁵⁶ Although the closure of Ode 17 creates a distinction between the two situations (myth and occasion) by differentiating the verbal tenses—the verbs that refer to the chorus *en route* to Crete are placed in the past (v.128 παιάνιξαν), whereas the verb referring to the god Apollo is in the present tense

55 On Ode 17 as either a paeon or a dithyramb, see e.g. Gerber 1965; Pieper 1972; Merkelbach 1973; Käppel 1992, 156-158, 184-189; Zimmermann 1992, 91-93; Hose 1995; Maehler 1997, 167-68; Rutherford 1997, 47-48, and 2001, 29, 35-36; Maehler 2004, 172-73; Pavlou 2012.

56 Cf. B.16.8 παιγόνων and the invocation of Pythian Apollo, on which Calame (2013, 344, 350-351) who draws attention to the invocations of Pythian Apollo (Ode 16) and Delian Apollo (Ode 17) in two poems that were classified as dithyrambs.

(v.131 ὅπαζε)—the poem does not unambiguously return to the *hic et nunc* of the occasion. The choral paeanic activity of the youths in the mythical narrative is in retrospect projected onto the actual choral performance of the Ceans. *POxy.2368* can also be called as evidence for the confusion that Bacchylides' civic poems create with reference to their poetic genre. The papyrus preserves a commentary on Bacchylides' *Dithyramb*s that records Aristarchus' disagreement with Callimachus about his *Kassandra*: Callimachus classified the poem *Kassandra* as a paeon, whereas Aristarchus considered it to be a dithyramb.⁵⁷ The puzzlement, both ancient and modern, about the genre of those poems of Bacchylides that were classified in the Hellenistic edition as *dithyramb*s,⁵⁸ or, in the case of the *Kassandra* poem, whose dithyrambic nature was called in question, presumably resulted not only from the lack of the original *Sitz im Leben* for the Alexandrians, but also from that of explicit textual elements that would point to a Dionysiac cultic context, or alternatively from the presence in the text of both dithyrambic and paeanic markers.

The poetics of Bacchylides reveal that in spite of his classical status within the established lyric tradition, he also experimented with it. Experimentation and innovation may be features claimed for the majority of poetry and literature in antiquity, but a predominantly Bacchylidean trait is that a number of features in his poetry, especially stylistic but also structural, as we have seen with Ode 18, as well as aesthetic qualities and effects in his work, seem to point to developments in the poetry of the latter half of the fifth century. To be sure, Bacchylides in many respects appears to be at odds with the New Music; he is metrically very regular, he does not abandon strophic structure, nor does he use *anaboliai* in his poems. Regardless of a number of key differences between his poetics and the New Dithyramb, his affinity with the new kind of poetry has led to his characterisation as one of the pioneers of the musical evolution of the fifth century.⁵⁹

57 D'Alessio 2013, 119–122 discusses the genre of Bacchylides' *Kassandra* in connection to *kuklioi khoroi*. Cf. B.fr.60, which closes with the semi-paeanic refrain *iē iē*. Despite this closure, the poem could plausibly be classified as a dithyramb because it is followed on the papyrus by fr.61, which like the rest of Bacchylides' dithyrambos is given a title.

58 The term '*dithyramb*' is italicised, as Bacchylides' *dithyramb*s, with the exception of Ode 19, cannot be associated with Dionysiac mythological and cultic contexts. It has recently been argued that the term '*kuklios khoros*' is probably more appropriate to refer to performances of public non-dramatic choral poetry in classical Athens as it avoids the cultic term *dithyrambos*. On *kuklioi khoroi* and the *dithyrambos*, Käppel 2000, 22–27; Fearn 2007, 163–180, 205–212; D'Alessio 2013; Ceccarelli 2013; on the differences between the poetics of the dithyrambos of Pindar and those of Bacchylides, Calame 2013.

59 Cf. Zimmermann 1992, 116 and 1993b, 54.

Aristophanes' Bacchylides

Let us return to Kinesias' scene in the *Birds*. The passage from Bacchylides that Aristophanes alludes to is one of the most vivid and energetic descriptions in Bacchylides. Neither ridicule of Kinesias nor parody of his verses by Peisetairos necessarily constitutes mockery or rejection of the poetry of Bacchylides. This may be no more than exploitation of a 'purple passage' in a new context. This new context is of fundamental importance for understanding Aristophanes' reception of Bacchylides, and one should pay attention again to the specifics of the scene. Kinesias combines in the image he crafts for himself two different metaphors which Bacchylides applies to his poetic stature—the nightingale (ἀηδών) and the bee (μέλισσαν).

καὶ νῦν κασιγνήτας ἀκοίτας
 νασιώτιν ἐκίνησεν λιγύφθογον μέλισσαν,
 ἐγχειρὲς ἴν' ἀθάνατον Μουσᾶν ἄγαλμα
 ξυνὸν ἀνθρώποισιν εἶη
 χάρμα...

(B.10.9-13)⁶⁰

But now his sister's husband has sent for the clear-voiced island bee, so that an eternal ornament of the Muses, a common delight for mankind, might be undertaken.

Kinesias takes the image of the bird, but he attributes to it the adjective that characterises the bee in Bacchylides (λιγύφθογον), and he wishes to become λιγύφθογος ἀηδών. It is rather puzzling that the image Bacchylides uses for his own portrayal is employed in the section with Kinesias and not in the scene caricaturing the archaic poet. If we pursue this paradox further, synthesis of verses from a classical ode in the voice of a modern and new melic poet could cast some light on the poetic and stylistic attributes that Bacchylides and his poetry may have had for Aristophanes, and also on his reception of Bacchylides. The altered Bacchylidean phrase λιγύφθογον μέλισσαν gains an additional resonance within the comic context of the particular scene; it may underscore the peculiar status of the poet Bacchylides and his poetry within the group of lyric poets. The parody of the grand lyric style in the preceding scene lends support to this assertion.

60 B.3.96-98 for the image of the nightingale is cited above.

Πο. Ἐγώ; μελιγλώσσων ἐπέων ἱεὺς ἀοιδᾶν
 Μουσᾶων θεράπων ὀτρη-
 ρός, κατὰ τὸν Ὅμηρον.
 (Ar.Av.908-910)

Poet: I am the Muses' eager servant, according to Homer, who launches a song of honey-tongued verses.

The image of the Muse's *therapōn* alludes to a number of passages,⁶¹ but Cairns correctly draws attention to the adjective μελιγλωσσος. It is found only in Bacchylides before Aristophanes, and it is found twice—B.3.97-98, and fr.4.63 μελιγλώσσων ἀοιδᾶν ('honey-tongued songs').⁶² In both Bacchylides and Aristophanes the adjective is used of poetic song (ἐπέων and ἀοιδᾶν), and this strengthens the connection between the two poets. Bacchylides, however, also employs it of himself (μελιγλώσσου ἀηδόνος), while the image of the nightingale describes Kinesias in the following scene. The distinction between old and new in Aristophanes and the broader musical and poetic context of the comedy become instrumental for any kind of interpretation. The Bacchylidean adjectives that are employed in both scenes to denote either traditional foundation songs (μελιγλώσσων ἐπέων) or the image of the New Poet Kinesias (λιγύφθογος ἀηδών), and the image of the nightingale that becomes the metaphorical vehicle for the poet both in Kinesias and in Bacchylides, support the assumption that for Aristophanes Bacchylides had a poetic status between the old and the new.

It is therefore not surprising that Bacchylides' name is not to be found in Aristophanes' work. He would have been a puzzling case. He was a poet who in many ways belonged in the same category as Simonides and Pindar—his poetry was traditional, commissioned by great patrons, composed and performed in the classical era—but he nonetheless attempted new things that could, at the time, have been considered radical. One cannot characterise him as a New Poet, but he can reasonably be treated as a first generation innovator. For Aristophanes melic poetry was only to be divided into two groups, in the same way that tragedy was assigned only two distinctive poets and

61 Μουσᾶων θεράπων: Hes.Th.100, Thgn.769, Hom.H. to Semele 19-20, Margites l.2. Θεράπων ὀτρηρός: Hom. Il.1.321; Od.1.109; 4.23, 38, 217.

62 Cairns (2010, 13) who also notes *Prometheus Bound* 173-4 μελιγλώσσοις πειθοῦς/ ἐπαοιδάϊσιν as possibly influenced by Bacchylides.

poetic eras:⁶³ old and respectable classic lyric poetry versus new and innovative music, both precisely differentiated. Aristophanes' apparent fondness for binary opposition can be identified in plots that "dramatise old and new generations (e.g. *Clouds*, *Wasps*), political ideologies (e.g. *Knights*, *Ecclesiazusae*), or poetic styles (e.g. *Thesmophoriazusae*, *Frogs*),"⁶⁴ while the conflict between the "traditional old" and the "unconventional new", as Rosen suggests,⁶⁵ could be used as an interpretative tool to identify the tension one can detect in Aristophanes' plays. Thus anything falling between these two distinct groups did not serve Aristophanes' purposes: the name would not represent a specific era. As it seems, Bacchylides could not have been classified in Aristophanes' comedies as representative either of the old or the new, since his poetry was not a clear case; it existed at the edges of both trends, as it was practically a mixture of a number of elements from both traditionally old and innovative new melic poetry.⁶⁶ Bacchylides was melic but in a Homeric manner,⁶⁷ and he experimented with the forms, notions and modes of the established melic poetry. He even reworked the Homeric *Iliad* in Ode 13,⁶⁸ an unprecedented endeavour in the surviving corpus of the classical era. A number of his poetic characteristics eventually became distinctive features of the New Music and shaped the New literary dithyramb. If Bacchylides was best known in Athens for his Athenian civic commissions, the tendency to see his poetry as in some way resembling the New Music would have been strengthened. It was especially with his *dithyrambic* compositions that his modern-new-musical tendencies were associated.

63 As Dover (1997, 6) has pointed out, in *Ranae* Aristophanes displays his fondness for binary opposition and the need for stark and obvious contrasts to make his point; the poetics of Aeschylus and Euripides are portrayed in the play as polar opposites and frame the poetics of the absent Sophocles, who is squashed in the middle between Aeschylus and Euripides, chronologically and poetically.

64 Rosen 2010, 242. It is clear that Aristophanes was looking for radical features in every aspect of life: the gluttons, the extremely wealthy, the leading politicians who were notorious, scandalous or more powerful and more successful than average, on which Sommerstein 1996.

65 Rosen 2010, 242.

66 With reference to Bacchylides' *dithyrambs* Garcia Romero (2000) has placed them in a medial position and has already claimed that they are essential documents for understanding the evolution of the genre in form and content.

67 E.g. Jebb 1906, 63; Kirkwood 1966, 100; Carey 1999, 20-1; Fearn 2007, 20-1; Cairns 2010, 45-57 with reference to the quasi-epic narrative style of his myths; on the Homeric quality of Bacchylides' persona, Hadjimichael 2010-2011.

68 See Fearn 2007, 120-143.

The co-existence of old and new elements turns Bacchylides into a puzzling figure in the canon of the lyric poets; he was the poet squeezed between classic lyric, as that was represented by the canonical nine, and the New Music, as represented by Kinesias. In this sense, he could have been perceived simultaneously as the boundary between the two poetic styles, and a *mélange* of the characteristic features of both groups.⁶⁹ He seems to have been the poet in the middle⁷⁰ and was therefore a difficult case for Aristophanes, whose texts⁷¹ distinguish precisely and accurately between archaic and classical melic poetry and New Music. Hence he cannot present Bacchylides as representative of either group, and he therefore remains unnamed. Yet the ‘in-betweenness’ characteristic of Bacchylides’ poetics and his ‘intermediary’ melic status have left their traces in the text of Aristophanes.

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69 Prauscello (2012) has recently argued convincingly in favour of the transitional phase that Pindar's epinician belonged to; she documents how his poetry proves that he cannot be perceived as the musically conservative figure presented in our sources. Her conclusion does not alter the conclusions drawn above on Bacchylides; rather it confirms the possibility of the co-existence of the traditional and the innovative in poets that have always been perceived as classic.

70 The characterisation could apply to his position in connection both with Pindar and Simonides and with the traditional classic melic poetry and the New Music.

71 As Hinds (1998, 50) points out, "the alluding poet is ultimately and necessarily a figure whom we ourselves read out from the text."

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